WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets

CONGO DRC

Africa

Information current as of November 2026

Dialogue | Trust | Partnership

office@lordwaverley.com
www.lordwaverley.com

WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Kinshasa	Capital and largest city; seat of government, the central bank and the main commercial, banking and consumer market	Financial services, construction, consumer goods, telecoms
Lualaba Province (Kolwezi)	Heart of the world's leading cobalt-producing region and Africa's largest copper output; venue of the central bank's October 2026 policy meeting	Copper and cobalt mining, processing, mining services
Haut-Katanga Province (Lubumbashi)	Second commercial hub of the southern Copperbelt and a key node on the rail link towards Zambia	Mining services, logistics, manufacturing, agro-processing
Lobito Corridor (Dilolo–Kolwezi–Lubumbashi)	Rail route linking the Copperbelt to Angola's Atlantic port of Lobito, backed by the US, the EU's Global Gateway and the G7 partnership	Rail and logistics, mineral exports, corridor infrastructure
Kongo Central (Banana and Matadi)	Atlantic gateway where DP World is building the country's first deep-water port, a $1.2 billion project targeting more than 450,000 containers a year	Ports, logistics, trade services
Inga hydropower site (lower Congo River)	Inga I and II have 1,775 MW installed, while the wider Grand Inga site has an estimated potential of around 39 GW	Hydropower, transmission, energy-intensive industry
Tanganyika Province (Manono)	Hosts globally significant lithium pegmatite resources and a historic tin and coltan mining district	Lithium, tin, battery-mineral exploration

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- ANAPI (National Agency for Investment Promotion) provides facilitation and guidance for foreign investors and administers Investment Code incentives, recording 386 projects worth $13.56 billion in 2019–2023
- Investment Code incentives, including tax breaks and duty exemptions linked to location, sector, jobs, training and exports, negotiated within a streamlined period of about 30 days
- Guichet Unique (one-stop shop) bringing together the government bodies involved in company registration
- Mining Code (2018) framework, requiring at least 10% Congolese ownership of mining companies, with ARECOMS administering cobalt export quotas of 96,600 tonnes a year for 2026 and 2027

- Joint-venture and local-partner routes in sectors with national-ownership rules, including retail (reserved for nationals), agribusiness (49% foreign ownership cap), telecoms (25% national ownership) and subcontracting
- Banque Centrale du Congo oversight of a largely dollarised banking system, with the Congolese franc broadly stable since late 2025 and reserves of about $7.8 billion at end-September 2026
- US-brokered Washington Accord (June 2025) and its Regional Economic Integration Framework covering energy, infrastructure, mining, national parks, tourism and public health, with scope for partnership with US investors

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

The Democratic Republic of the Congo in October 2026 combines strong growth with markedly improved macroeconomic stability. The IMF reports real GDP growth above 5.5% in 2025, with construction, services and agriculture now broadening growth beyond mining, and the central bank forecasts 5.7% for 2026. Inflation has fallen to around 3.4% year-on-year (September 2026), well below the 7% target, allowing the Banque Centrale du Congo to cut its policy rate from 17.5% in December 2025 to 12.5% in August 2026. International reserves reached $8.18 billion (about 3.1 months of imports) in mid-2026, and the IMF completed its third Extended Credit Facility review in June 2026, bringing disbursements to nearly $1.03 billion. The country's inaugural Eurobond and new public-finance reforms mark its entry into international capital markets. FDI inflows eased to $1.87 billion in 2025 from $3.11 billion in 2024, while the FDI stock rose to $38.6 billion.

The DRC's main structural challenge is insecurity in the eastern provinces, where the AFC/M23 rebellion holds Goma and Bukavu, having briefly taken Uvira in December 2025 before withdrawing in January 2026. The conflict is geographically distant from the southern Copperbelt, where most large-scale mining investment is located, and diplomacy has advanced: the US-brokered Washington Accord between the DRC and Rwanda was signed in June 2025, a Regional Economic Integration Framework was agreed in November 2025, and the DRC and M23 signed a Doha framework agreement on 15 November 2025. Investors can mitigate exposure through site selection, security planning and supply-chain due diligence. As the peace frameworks are implemented, they open a sizeable opportunity in regional energy, infrastructure and responsibly sourced minerals, while new export routes such as the Lobito Corridor and the Banana deep-water port strengthen access to world markets.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Insecurity in the eastern provinces	AFC/M23 controls key eastern cities, including Goma and Bukavu, affecting operations and logistics in North and South Kivu	Concentrate initial exposure in the southern Copperbelt and Kinshasa; follow the Washington and Doha peace frameworks, which could unlock regional integration projects
Targeted sanctions and conflict-minerals compliance	The US, UN and others maintain targeted, list-based DRC sanctions on specific persons and groups, with US designations as recently as June 2026; eastern 3T and gold supply chains carry heightened due-diligence requirements	Retain sanctions counsel, screen all counterparties and apply OECD-standard supply-chain due diligence; compliant, traceable supply chains are increasingly valued by buyers
Cobalt export quotas and regulatory change	Cobalt exports, suspended from February 2025, have been capped by quota since October 2025 at 96,600 tonnes a year for 2026–2027, and an ARECOMS platform outage in 2026 delayed shipments	Engage ARECOMS early and build quota timelines into plans; the policy has supported cobalt prices and favours investment in local processing
Power and transport infrastructure	Only about 10% of households have electricity, and Inga I and II operate at around 40% of capacity	Plan for on-site or contracted power; the infrastructure gap itself is a large opportunity in hydropower, transmission, rail and ports
Governance and contract enforcement	Courts can be slow and disputes can last years; the IMF has called for stronger anti-corruption and anti-money-laundering efforts	Use ANAPI-negotiated incentive agreements, international arbitration clauses and experienced local counsel; a new economic and financial tribunal, IMF-backed reforms and the DRC's October

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
		2026 exit from the FATF grey list mark progress
Concentration in minerals and export markets	Mining drives exports, and China took about 69% of exports in 2023	Diversified non-mining growth in construction, services and agriculture, and new Western corridor partnerships, are broadening the investor base
Local-content and ownership rules	National-ownership requirements apply in mining, agribusiness, telecoms, retail and subcontracting	Structure entry through reputable Congolese partners and local suppliers, building goodwill and alignment with national development goals

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

The DRC's risk profile reflects an economy with world-class mineral resources, strong growth and a clear improvement in macroeconomic management, anchored by an IMF programme, single-digit inflation, falling interest rates and rising reserves. Insecurity in the east is the principal risk and should be stated plainly: armed groups, including AFC/M23, control parts of North and South Kivu, and the peace frameworks agreed in Washington and Doha in 2025 are still being implemented. Investors should also note that the US, the UN and other jurisdictions operate targeted, list-based DRC sanctions on specific individuals, armed groups and some entities, so counterparty screening, sanctions counsel and OECD-standard minerals due diligence are essential, particularly for eastern tin, tantalum, tungsten and gold supply chains. These measures are not a general trade embargo, and the large-scale copper and cobalt operations of the southern Copperbelt remain open to lawful international investment. With sound compliance, early engagement with regulators and careful site selection, investors can position for a market whose role in global energy-transition supply chains continues to grow.

MARKET ACCESS

The DRC is a member of the Southern African Development Community (SADC), the Common Market for Eastern and Southern Africa (COMESA), the Economic Community of Central African States (ECCAS) and, since July 2022, the East African Community (EAC), giving it an unusually wide set of regional trade links, and it is a signatory to the African Continental Free Trade Area and a WTO member. China is the dominant export market, taking about 69% of exports in 2023, followed by the United Arab Emirates at about 7%. Copper and cobalt move south and east by rail and road through Zambia, and increasingly west along the Lobito Corridor, which links Kolwezi and Lubumbashi to the Atlantic and delivered the first DRC copper shipment to the United States in August 2024. The DP World deep-water port at Banana, targeted for completion in early 2027, will add a direct Atlantic gateway for the west of the country.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Office of the President (Félix Tshisekedi)	Sets overall strategy on mining, security and the US and regional partnerships, including the Washington Accord	Primary reference point for the country's strategic direction
ANAPI (National Agency for Investment Promotion)	Lead investment promotion agency; administers Investment Code incentives	Standard first point of contact for market entry and incentive negotiation
Banque Centrale du Congo (Governor André Wameso)	Monetary authority; has cut the policy rate to 12.5% as inflation has fallen	Relevant for currency, banking and foreign-exchange matters
ARECOMS (strategic minerals regulator)	Administers cobalt export quotas and decides who exports and how much	Essential counterpart for any cobalt or strategic-minerals investment
Gécamines (state mining company)	Holds minority stakes in major copper-cobalt joint ventures	Key partner for mining joint ventures and asset access
Office of the Prime Minister (Judith Suminwa) and Ministry of Finance	Lead the IMF-supported programme, budget and Eurobond-funded investment plans	Relevant for public-investment, PPP and fiscal-incentive matters

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Ministry of Foreign Affairs	Signed the Washington Accord with Rwanda and leads regional peace and integration diplomacy	Relevant for understanding the peace process and regional integration opportunities

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The Fédération des Entreprises du Congo (FEC) is the main national business federation and a practical source of local partners, and the annual DRC Mining Week in Lubumbashi is the leading meeting point for the Copperbelt mining community. ANAPI provides investor facilitation and incentive guidance. The IMF and World Bank are closely engaged on reforms, while the Lobito Corridor brings together the US, the EU's Global Gateway, the G7 Partnership for Global Infrastructure and the Africa Finance Corporation, creating a natural platform for infrastructure, logistics and mining investors. Major international mining companies operating in Lualaba and Haut-Katanga are a useful source of practical intelligence on logistics, power and regulatory processes.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

The DRC best suits investors with experience in frontier and resource markets and a strong compliance culture: mining and processing companies seeking long-term exposure to copper, cobalt and battery minerals; infrastructure, rail and port investors aligned with the Lobito Corridor and the Banana deep-water port; energy investors in hydropower, off-grid and transmission projects addressing the large power gap; and development finance institutions and impact investors able to support growth in agriculture, construction and services. Investors with exposure to eastern supply chains should apply OECD-standard due diligence and sanctions screening.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage ANAPI and assess Investment Code incentives
Open early dialogue with the national investment promotion agency to negotiate sector-specific tax and customs incentives under the Investment Code.

STEP 2: Establish a sanctions and minerals due-diligence framework
Retain sanctions counsel, screen all counterparties and partners, and apply OECD-standard supply-chain due diligence before entering the market.

STEP 3: Prioritise the southern Copperbelt and Kinshasa for initial entry
Focus first on Lualaba, Haut-Katanga and Kinshasa, while building security and logistics planning into any wider operations.

STEP 4: Engage ARECOMS and Gécamines on mining structures
Clarify quota allocations, export procedures and joint-venture options early for any copper, cobalt or strategic-minerals project.

STEP 5: Position for corridor and energy opportunities
Follow the Lobito Corridor, the Banana deep-water port and the Inga hydropower programme, alongside implementation of the 2025 peace and regional integration frameworks.